The NYC School System

Applying to school,
starting at age 4



Warm-up

Where are these schools?



A



B



C



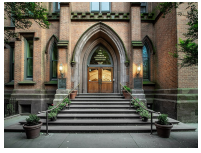
D



E

Which of these are actually in New York? Why do you think so?

They're all in New York City



Packer Collegiate



Nightingale-Bamford



Trinity School



Stuyvesant



Bronx Science

- **A, B, C:** private schools. Tuition: about **$69,000 a year** (Trinity, 2025–26)
- **D, E:** public schools. Tuition: **$0**, but you need a top score on an entrance exam
- In 2026–27, at least **seven** NYC private schools charge more than **$70,000 a year**

Sources: Fortune, Feb. 2025; Bloomberg, Feb. 2026. Photos: Ajay Suresh, CC BY 2.0 (Packer, Nightingale-Bamford); Jay Dobkin, CC BY-SA 4.0 (Trinity); Kidfly182, CC BY-SA 4.0 (Stuyvesant); Bxsstudent, public domain (Bronx Science). All via Wikimedia Commons.

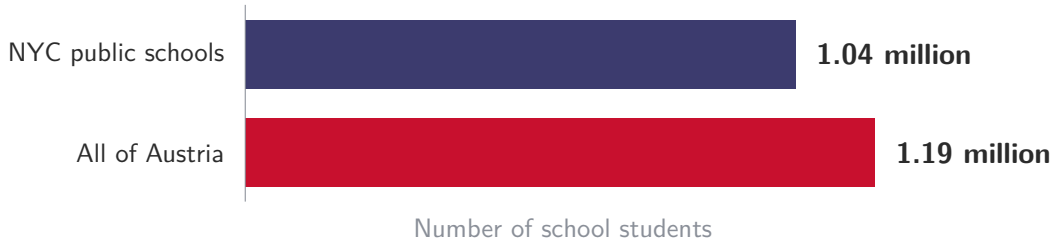
Basic Info

NYC schools by the numbers

- **About 885,000** students in NYC Public Schools (3-K to 12th grade, 2025–26)
- **Plus about 151,000** in public charter schools (publicly funded, privately run)
- **1,599** schools run by NYC Public Schools
- **Roughly 200,000** in private schools, most of them religious (Jewish and Catholic)
- About **73%** of public school students live in poverty; **14%** are homeless or in temporary housing

Sources: NYC Public Schools, *Data at a Glance* (2025–26); NYC Comptroller, *Tracking the K-12 Student Population in NYC* (Oct. 2026).

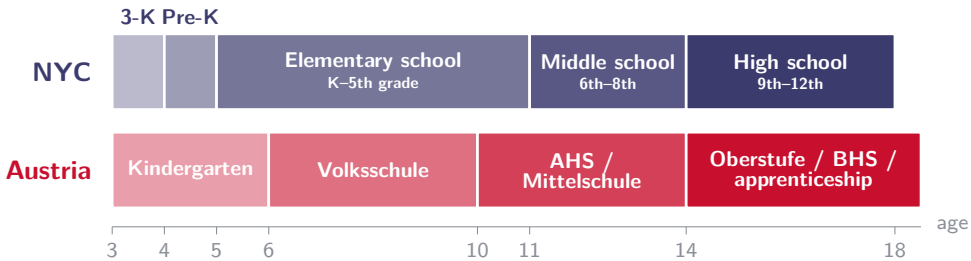
One city, one country



NYC's public schools are almost as big as Austria's entire school system.

Sources: NYC Public Schools (2025–26, district + charter schools); Statistik Austria via ORF (2024/25: 1,185,525 students).

The basic structure



- In NYC, 3-K and Pre-K are free, but not compulsory

The Path to College

Remember: getting into college



Fewer than 1 in 20 applicants get in.

Sources: Yale News, Mar. 2026 (2,328 of 54,919); Columbia via *Columbia Spectator* (2,581 of 61,031); *Harvard Crimson*, Oct. 2025 (Class of 2029: 2,003 of 47,893).

But. . .

- Most American colleges admit most students who apply
- More than half of four-year colleges accept **two-thirds** or more of applicants
- Only **17** of about 1,364 four-year colleges accepted fewer than **10%**
- The pressure is about getting into the top schools, and in NYC that race starts early

Source: Pew Research Center, 2019 (data for 2017).

For NYC students, the application process begins in pre-K.

Applying to elementary school

- Every 5-year-old in NYC is guaranteed a kindergarten seat, but not at a specific school
- Families rank schools; if a school has more applicants than seats, there's a lottery
- Who gets priority (in order):

  1. Live in the school's **zone** and have a **sibling** there
  2. Live in the school's **zone**
  3. Have a **sibling** at the school (but live outside the zone)
  4. Attend the school's **pre-K**

Source: NYC Public Schools, kindergarten admissions (fall 2027 cycle).

Gifted and Talented (G&T)

- Separate, accelerated classes, starting in kindergarten
- About **2,500** kindergarten seats a year; about 18,000 G&T students in total
- How do 4-year-olds get in?
  - Public pre-K students: their **pre-K teacher** evaluates them
  - Private pre-K or no pre-K: an **interview** with the Education Department
  - Eligible children then enter a **lottery**
- Until 2021, children took a test at age 4
- **Mayor Mamdani** wants to stop admitting kindergartners to G&T; for now the program continues (fall 2027 applications open Dec. 2026)

Sources: NYC Public Schools, Gifted and Talented; AP and news reports, 2025–26.

Elementary school

- School day: about **8:30 a.m. to 3:00 p.m.** (6 hours 20 minutes; times vary by school)
- One main teacher, one classroom, the same classmates all day
- Subjects: Math, English Language Arts (ELA), Science, Social Studies, Spanish, Music, Technology
- After **5th grade** (age 10–11): you must apply to middle school

Source: Chalkbeat, Apr. 2026 (length of the school day).

Applying to middle school

- Apply in the fall of 5th grade and rank schools in order of preference
- Some schools use a lottery with priorities (e.g. living in the district)
- Others screen students using **4th-grade report card grades**
- This is when many families **leave** the public schools: the biggest drop in enrollment happens between 5th and 6th grade
- Example: my middle school, **MS 54 Booker T. Washington** (Upper West Side): ms54.org/admissions

Sources: NYC Public Schools, middle school admissions; NYC Comptroller, Oct. 2026.

Watch: a school tour

Watch:

Elster school tour

Applying to High School

Three separate applications

- **1. Specialized High Schools** (8 schools): admission by one test only, the SHSAT
  - e.g. Stuyvesant, Bronx Science, Brooklyn Tech
- **2. LaGuardia High School** (performing and visual arts): admission by audition or portfolio
- **3. The main application:** 700+ programs at 400+ high schools
  - **Screened** programs: grades, attendance, sometimes interviews
  - **Audition** programs, e.g. Frank Sinatra School of the Arts
  - **Open** programs: lottery
- Each application can give you at most one offer

Source: NYC Public Schools, high school admissions.

Happening right now

- This month, about **26,000** NYC 8th graders take the SHSAT
  - Test days: **Nov. 14/15 and 21, 2026**
- High school applications are due **Dec. 4, 2026**
- Offers arrive **March 3, 2027**

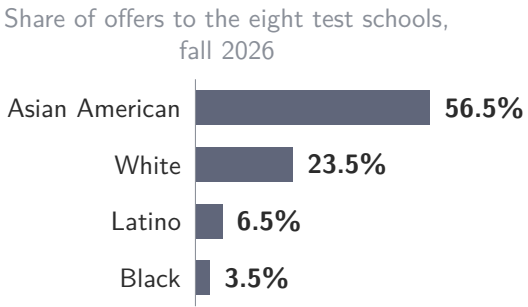
Source: NYC Public Schools, fall 2027 admissions calendar.

The SHSAT

- **3 hours**, **100 questions** (50 English, 50 Math), no calculator
- New in 2026: taken on a computer, and adaptive: get a question right and the next one is harder
- Your score is the only thing that counts. No grades, no interviews, no essays
- About **26,100** students took it last year; about **4,000** got an offer (about **1 in 6**)
- Lowest score that got into Stuyvesant: **561** (2026 admissions)

Sources: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions*; Chalkbeat, July 2026.

Who gets in?



- Stuyvesant offered seats to **3** Black students
- **Supporters** of the test: it's objective, the same rules for everyone
- **Critics**: it favors families who can pay for test prep and leaves out Black and Latino students
- Mayor Mamdani has said he will **keep** the test and study it for bias

Source: Chalkbeat, July 2026.

No guarantee

- Applying to all three is far from a guarantee
- At my middle school, about **30 students** got **no** high school offer at all in the first round
- There's usually no "default" school: most NYC high schools aren't zoned
- Students without an offer go on **waitlists** and are placed later at a school with open seats
- Citywide (2024): about **3%** of applicants got no offer to any school on their list

Source: NYC Public Schools, 2024 admissions cycle data release.

What does high school look like?

- Highly dependent on which school you go to
- Some schools have **thousands** of students; others fewer than **150**
- Specialized schools: very competitive, lots of homework, many AP courses
- Small schools: themes like law, health, technology, or the arts

My high school

- About **150 students per grade**
- An "Early College" program: college courses during high school, for free college credit
- A **5-story** building

> Take a look:
> Google Street View

My schedule

Period	Monday		Tuesday		Wednesday		Thursday		Friday	
2	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45	PFS11Q1Y/3 Introduction to ARPAIO	Room REM 9:55-10:45	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45
3			MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40	MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40	MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40	MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40
4	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	GAS86/7 CTO Advisory NOLAN	Room REM 11:45-12:35
5										
6	FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25			FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25	FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25	FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25
7	SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20	SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20	SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20			SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20
8										
9					ZQWT/33 Writing and Thi ILBOUDO	Room REM 4:20- 5:10				

College-level courses: Calculus I, Latin, Intro to General Biology, Cervantes' *Don Quixote*

Next step: college

- At my school, getting A's was relatively easy
- So: "spam" extracurriculars, i.e. do as many as you can
- Popular activities at my school:
  - **Clubs:** Quiz Bowl, Model UN, Debate
  - **Sports:** Frisbee, Tennis

Compare

Sorting students: NYC vs. Austria

	NYC	Austria
First selection	G&T at **4–5**	Gymnasium (AHS) or Mittelschule at **10**
Middle school	Apply at **10–11** (lottery or grades)	Based on Volksschule grades
High school	Apply at **13–14**; one test for the top 8 schools	Oberstufe, BHS (HTL, HAK . . .) or apprenticeship at **14**
Private schools	Many, up to **$70,000+** a year	Mostly Catholic, far cheaper
University	Applications, essays, tests; under 5% at top schools	Matura, then mostly **open** admission; free for EU students (within standard study time)

Sources: NYC Public Schools; oesterreich.gv.at; studium.at.

Think

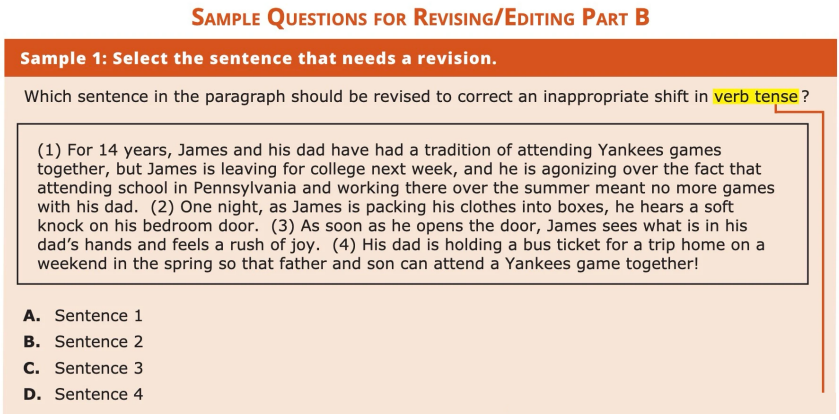
Austria is often criticized for sorting kids at 10.
Is New York better or worse?

Final Activity

Could you get into Stuyvesant?

- In your groups: answer **5 real questions** from the official SHSAT guide
- No calculators!
- Write down your answers; we'll check them after each question
- Real 8th graders get less than **2 minutes** per question

Question 1 of 5: English



Sample Questions for Revising/Editing Part B

Sample 1: Select the sentence that needs a revision.

Which sentence in the paragraph should be revised to correct an inappropriate shift in verb tense?

(1) For 14 years, James and his dad have had a tradition of attending Yankees games together, but James is leaving for college next week, and he is agonizing over the fact that attending school in Pennsylvania and working there over the summer meant no more games with his dad. (2) One night, as James is packing his clothes into boxes, he hears a soft knock on his bedroom door. (3) As soon as he opens the door, James sees what is in his dad's hands and feels a rush of joy. (4) His dad is holding a bus ticket for a trip home on a weekend in the spring so that father and son can attend a Yankees game together!

A. Sentence 1
B. Sentence 2
C. Sentence 3
D. Sentence 4

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 1: answer

Sample 1 Explanation

(A) The sentence is written in the present tense; the verb “meant” shifts incorrectly into past tense. This verb should instead appear in the future tense, “will mean,” since the verb refers to how things will be in the future. The corrected sentence will then read, “For 14 years, James and his dad have had a tradition of attending Yankees games together, but James is leaving for college next week, and he is agonizing over the fact that attending school in Pennsylvania and working there over the summer will mean no more games with his dad.” The present tense, “means,” could also be used, as James appears to be coming to this realization in present time. The use of “means” would make the corrected sentence read as follows: “For 14 years, James and his dad have had a tradition of attending Yankees games together, but James is leaving for college next week, and he is agonizing over the fact that attending school in Pennsylvania and working there over the summer means no more games with his dad.”

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Questions 2–4: read the passage

Sample Questions for Revising/Editing Part A

Learning to Embrace the Gap Year

(1) The traditional academic plan for college-bound students in the United States is to complete high school in June and begin college courses in August or September, but some experts wonder whether this plan is appropriate for all students. (2) Young adults are still exhausted from attending secondary school. (3) They are sent to college with little to no transition time. (4) They struggle with a lack of direction, have minimal life experience, and are not adequately prepared to succeed. (5) Many students are simply starting college before they are ready.

(6) A gap year is when a student takes a one- year hiatus from schooling for nonacademic activities. (7) This break in the academic track gives young adults a chance to explore possible program options, gain volunteer experience, and achieve personal growth. (8) Through a variety of opportunities, gap year participants can develop new skills and interests. (9) The break can also help prepare students for the challenges of college coursework by giving them additional time to mature. (10) Succeeding at the college level can be challenging at first, but when determined students adjust and employ good study habits, they will thrive.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Questions 2–4: read the passage (continued)

(11) Earning money can be a tempting choice, and some young adults may find that they no longer desire a college degree after entering the workforce. (12) While gap year critics do have a valid concern, a 2010 Wall Street Journal article cited research that found that "90% of students who took a gap year had returned to college within a year." (13) And the Gap Year Association, a worldwide accredited nonprofit that promotes the benefits of a gap year, maintains that "taking a structured gap year invariably serves to develop the individual into a more focused student with a better sense of purpose and engagement in the world."

(14) The choice to take a gap year may not be for all students, but it could be the best path for some. (15) Students need to know that this is a good choice that will be supported if it is what they want. (16) Taking a gap year could help students become more successful as adults in their community.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 2 of 5: English

1. Which sentence should follow sentence 5 to introduce the main claim of the passage?

A. Taking a gap year away from formal education to determine their personal aspirations is the answer for these students.

B. For some students, the benefits of taking a gap year after high school could significantly increase their chances of achieving collegiate success.

C. When students are academically and emotionally prepared, they are guaranteed to experience greater success in their higher education endeavors.

D. Students who take the time to mature and gain knowledge outside of the classroom will experience more satisfaction, purpose, and accomplishment in their life.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 2: answer

Sample 1 Explanation

(B) Option B is the best sentence to follow sentence 5 and supports the main claim. This sentence clearly states the claim in that the gap year can lead to success in college for some, but not all, students (as revealed in sentence 14). This idea is developed throughout the passage by explaining what a gap year is and how it benefits students.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 3 of 5: English

2. Which revision of sentence 8 uses the **most** precise language?

E. Through different experiences and discoveries, gap year participants can develop new skills and interests.

F. Through a range of opportunities and training, gap year participants can develop new skills and interests.

G. Through internships, work, travel, or volunteerism, gap year participants can develop new skills and interests.

H. Through a variety of jobs, programs, and charities, gap year participants can develop new skills and interests.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 3: answer

Sample 2 Explanation

(G) Option G uses the most precise language and is the correct response. The imprecise reference in sentence 8 to “a variety of opportunities” is replaced with the more specific and precise reference to what these opportunities entail. They may be “internships, work, travel, or volunteerism.”

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 4 of 5: English

3. Which sentence should be added before sentence 11 to introduce the ideas in the third paragraph (sentences 11 - 13)?

A. Some gap year opponents worry that young adults who take a break from academia for activities such as a job may never return.

B. In addition to helping students become better prepared for college, a gap year could be useful to those with financial constraints.

C. Students complain that there is not enough time between high school and college to earn money for college.

D. There is growing concern among some experts that a gap year may be too expensive for many students to even consider.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 4: answer

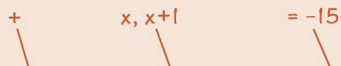
Sample 3 Explanation

(A) Option A is the correct sentence to add before sentence 11. The third paragraph introduces, and then refutes, a counterclaim about gap years in that they may encourage young people to forgo college entirely. This sentence clearly introduces this counterclaim that the paragraph elaborates on and then refutes with evidence.

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 5 of 5: Math

Sample 1



The sum of two consecutive integers is −15. If 1 is added to the smaller integer and 2 is subtracted from the larger integer, what is the **product** of the two resulting integers?

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 5: answer

63

- Call the two integers x and $x+1$: $x + (x+1) = -15$, so $x = -8$
- The integers are -8 and -7
- Add 1 to the smaller: $-8 + 1 = -7$. Subtract 2 from the larger: $-7 - 2 = -9$
- Product: $(-7) \times (-9) = 63$

Source: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

How did you do?

- Which group got the most right?
- Which section was harder for you: English or Math? Why?
- Should one test decide who gets into the best public high schools?